Azure Virtual Desktop: Questions and Resources

This handout answers the questions attendees ask most often and lists where to read more.

Status: prepared 2026-10-06; cloud-only Azure Files guidance reviewed 2026-10-09 against Microsoft Learn; prices and support change, so follow the pricing and documentation links.

Choosing a deployment model

Which components always live in Azure? The Azure Virtual Desktop service components: host pools, workspaces and application groups.

Where can session hosts run? On Azure, on Azure Local (your cluster), or on your own hypervisor with Azure Virtual Desktop Hybrid.

Can one workspace include more than one deployment model? Yes. One workspace can show desktops from host pools of several models. A host pool is either all Azure or all Azure Local.

How should I choose?

- Azure for elasticity and the least infrastructure.
- Azure Local when data or latency keeps compute on site and you have Azure Local.
- Hybrid to reuse an existing hypervisor without new hardware.

What should I confirm for the host operating system?

- Azure Local needs version 23H2 or later registered with Azure, and supports Windows 11 Enterprise (multi-session and single-session), Windows 10 Enterprise, and Windows Server 2025, 2022 and 2019.
- Hybrid supports Windows 11 or 10 Enterprise single-session and Windows Server, but not multi-session. It has no power management, autoscale, Start VM on Connect or session host configuration.
- The Realm Comparison handout covers all thirteen axes.

Identity and sign-in

Can users be cloud-only or hybrid? Yes. Hybrid users are synced with Microsoft Entra Connect Sync or Microsoft Entra Cloud Sync.

Do session hosts need AD DS? Not Microsoft Entra-joined Windows client hosts. Windows Server hosts need AD DS or hybrid join.

What enables single sign-on? It uses the Azure Virtual Desktop and Windows Cloud Login applications; keep their Conditional Access policies aligned.

Which role do users need on Microsoft Entra-joined hosts? The Virtual Machine User Login role. Use Conditional Access for MFA, not per-user MFA.

The Identity Reference Architecture handout has the detail.

Profiles

How does FSLogix store profiles? In VHDX containers on an SMB share, attached at sign-in.

What is the cloud-first storage option? Azure Files with Microsoft Entra Kerberos supports cloud-only identities as generally available in the public cloud. Cloud-only SMB authentication needs no domain controller; hybrid ACL administration and on-premises resource access can still need one. A storage account uses one identity source.

What storage works with Azure Local hosts? A file server VM, Scale-Out File Server on the cluster, or Azure Files. FSLogix needs an SMB service, not a cluster shared volume path.

Roaming, redundancy and recovery? Cloud Cache gives redundancy across storage providers. Roaming a profile is not replication, and replication is not recovery.

The FSLogix Configuration Guide has the settings.

Images

How do I build and publish images for Azure hosts? Build with Azure Image Builder or your own pipeline, publish to an Azure Compute Gallery, and deploy hosts from an image version.

How are Azure Local images supplied? As an Azure Local VM image, for example from Azure Marketplace images, a gallery or a VHD import.

How are Hybrid images built? Typically with Packer and the platform builder for your hypervisor.

Any practices to keep? Share customisation scripts between realms and do not bake identity into an image. For pooled pools, this session's practice is to replace hosts from a new image version instead of patching in place; that is the session's practice, not a Microsoft requirement.

Networking

Do I open inbound ports? No. Clients and hosts make outbound TCP 443 connections to the service, and the required URL list must be allowed.

Which Azure platform addresses must not be intercepted? `169.254.169.254` and `168.63.129.16`.

What does RDP Shortpath do? It adds a UDP transport for better reliability and latency, on managed networks and on public networks (STUN or TURN).

What latency and region rules apply? Client-to-region round-trip latency should be below 150 ms, and session hosts on Azure must be in a virtual network in the same region.

Scaling and cost

What costs apply to each model?

- Azure: Azure compute and storage, plus the user licence.
- Azure Local: the Azure Local service fee, the Azure Virtual Desktop for Azure Local service fee (charged per active vCPU of session hosts), and the user licence.
- Hybrid: your infrastructure, the user licence, and the Azure Virtual Desktop Hybrid service user license.

For amounts, use the Azure Virtual Desktop and Azure Local pricing pages.

Which user licences are eligible?

- Windows client session hosts: Microsoft 365 E3, E5, A3, A5, F3, Business Premium or Student Use Benefit; Windows Enterprise E3 or E5; Windows Education A3 or A5; Windows VDA per user.

- Windows Server session hosts: an RDS CAL with Software Assurance, or RDS User Subscription Licenses.
- External commercial users: per-user access pricing (Windows client only).
- Azure Dev/Test pricing lets users connect to a deployment in a Dev/Test subscription for acceptance tests without separate licence entitlement.

What autoscale options exist? Scaling plans work for pooled and personal host pools on Azure. Power management autoscale is generally available; dynamic autoscale is in preview and needs a session host configuration. Session host configuration is not supported on Azure Local, and Hybrid has none of these features.

What else keeps cost down? Right-size VMs from measured usage and use multi-session. Do not use autoscale and the Azure Automation scaling tool on the same host pool.

Security

What is the default VM security type in the Azure host pool flow? Trusted launch.

How do I apply MFA and access control? Use Conditional Access with MFA through the Azure Virtual Desktop and Windows Cloud Login applications, and least-privilege roles: Desktop Virtualization Contributor for host pool management and Desktop Virtualization User for application group users.

What about Azure Local machines? They require TPM 2.0 and Secure Boot. Keep agents and Windows updated.

Monitoring and support

Where do diagnostics go? To a Log Analytics workspace, with Azure Virtual Desktop Insights on top.

How do Azure Local and Hybrid hosts report? Through the Azure Arc agent, into the same workspace.

Which patching tool applies? Azure Update Manager covers Windows Server, not Windows 10 or 11 guests; use Intune or Windows Update for Business for those.

What do I collect before a support request? The agent events from the session host (RDAgent), along with the host pool name and region.

Quick troubleshooting

Symptom	What to check
Host shows Unavailable after a registration problem	Event 3277, then generate a new registration key (valid from 1 hour to 27 days).
Sign-in works but the desktop will not open	The Virtual Machine User Login role, and the Windows Cloud Login application in Conditional Access.
Repeated sign-in prompts	Align the two Conditional Access policies and disable per-user MFA.
Profile will not attach	The share path, permissions, the Kerberos ticket, and whether the storage application is excluded from MFA.
Windows App sign-in error with Conditional Access	Whether a policy blocks the Windows 365 application.
Hosts not scaling	The role on the Azure Virtual Desktop service principal, and that the host pool is not using two scaling tools.

Resources

Microsoft Learn topics:

- Prerequisites for Azure Virtual Desktop
- Licensing Azure Virtual Desktop
- Azure Virtual Desktop on Azure Local
- Azure Virtual Desktop Hybrid overview
- Required FQDNs and endpoints for Azure Virtual Desktop
- Configure single sign-on for Azure Virtual Desktop using Microsoft Entra ID
- Enforce Microsoft Entra multifactor authentication for Azure Virtual Desktop using Conditional Access
- FSLogix: configure profile containers
- FSLogix: store profile containers on Azure Files using Microsoft Entra ID
- Autoscale scaling plans for Azure Virtual Desktop
- Azure Virtual Desktop Insights
- RDP Shortpath for Azure Virtual Desktop
- Azure Virtual Desktop pricing

In this repository:

- Realm comparison
- Identity reference architecture
- FSLogix configuration guide
- Deployment checklist

Cloud-only Azure Files guidance reviewed 9 October 2026: Azure Files GA release notes, Entra Kerberos prerequisites, and supported directory ACL methods.